



U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs

Veterans Health Administration
Digital Health Office

Discovery Sprint Guide

Version 1

October 2024

OUTLINE

1. What Is a Discovery Sprint?
2. Why Run a Discovery Sprint?
3. How Long Does It Take?
4. How to Run a Discovery Sprint
5. Why Sprints Fail – Pitfalls to Avoid
6. Best Practices

Before you start designing or building a service, you need to find out who the potential users are and what problems your service could solve for them.

It's tempting to start brainstorming solutions right away based on your understanding of your project. Doing that leads to a solution-focused design process in which your team's primary question is: How do we build the solution?

Instead focus on a user-centered design process in which your team's primary questions are: Who are the potential users of my service, and how can we design a service that meets their needs?

Discovery sprints are rapid, focused investigations designed to gain a comprehensive understanding of complex organizational systems, services, or challenges.

The purpose of a discovery sprint is to identify root causes, issues, and opportunities, not to solve them in this time window.

WHY RUN A DISCOVERY SPRINT?

- Rapid assessment of complex situations
- Holistic view of organizational challenges
- Identification of non-obvious issues
- Data-driven, user-centered approach to problem-solving
- Clear next steps for organizational improvement

HOW LONG DOES IT TAKE?

Discovery sprints are typically time boxed to a **2–4-week commitment** of intensive work.

Urgency keeps everyone focused on the high-level goals to gain understanding of, but not solve problems immediately. Sometimes sprints need to extend but it's important to look back at the goals and avoid scope creep.

RUNNING A DISCOVERY SPRINT

First, Prepare

It can be tempting to jump into meetings and figure out logistics as you go, but preparing can help your team work quickly, stay organized, and stay focused while you take in a lot of new information.

Identify a Sprint Team Lead

Sprint team leads serve as the main point of contact and are responsible for stakeholder relationship management as well as preparing for and guiding the sprint team through every stage.

Scope the Sprint

Set a sprint goal to be sure that the team's focus is clear. Setting a north star goal can help teams stay focused and avoid scope creep.

Develop a Problem Statement

A good problem statement will include a description of the people at the receiving end of the tool or service, what they're trying to accomplish, and the implications for not addressing any known issues (number of people affected and how severely, budget concerns, etc.).

Problem statement template:

As a [primary user], I need [resource] so I can [achieve desired result] in order to [achieve mission aligned outcome].

The purpose of a discovery sprint is a new perspective, so it is entirely possible that the problems identified at this stage may not end up being the same as what the discovery sprint reports back at the end.

Staff the Sprint

Sprint teams are necessarily small, usually 4-6 people. Sprint teams need to move quickly and the larger the team, the more communication and coordination is needed. A typical team has the following skillsets:

- Project leadership (the sprint team lead)
- Product management
- Design and User Research expertise
- Technical expertise
- Policy or legal expertise
- Procurement knowledge
- Communication and presentation skills

Prepare as a Team

By the time you arrive at the kick-off meeting together you should appear to your partners and stakeholders as a cohesive and collaborative team with a strong leader. Make sure everyone has a consistent message of who the team is and why you're there.

Identify Your Partners

The sprint team lead should work with the stakeholder organization to identify some or all of the following people:

- Senior Executive Sponsor
- Sprint Champion
- Administrative Contact
- Subject Matter Experts
- End Users

Plan Logistics

Ideally logistics are coordinated ahead of time to help the sprint run smoothly after kick-off. For in person sprints, travel and access will need to be considered.

- Schedule session as far in advance as possible
- Use available tools
- Plan for secure research artifacts
 - Create structure for capturing insights, recordings, and documents.

This is especially a concern if you are screen sharing to look at a participant's work, or if their work reveals their (or a third party's) PII, PHI or other sensitive information.

Consider the potential trade-offs are for the topics you may be covering:

- A test account, or dummy log-in information may be just fine to show you what you need to learn, without putting anyone's data at risk.
- Screenshots of a step-by-step process can be gathered before or after an interview session and even printed out and redacted then photographed or scanned by an interview participant.
- Drawing or post-it type diagramming can be done collaboratively in tools like Mural or Miro.

Run the Sprint

Some things to keep in mind and revisit often while you are doing your discovery:

- Work from a learning mindset: you are there to learn from and enable your partners
- The organization has tremendous expertise and will have expended significant effort in this problem space already
- You are very likely not the first team that has shown up to help them on these issues
- They are also setting time aside for you on top of their other responsibilities
- Lastly, a reminder that the point of discovery is to look for the root causes and opportunities

It can be easy to fall back to a mode of just identifying all the problems and why they are harmful. It's easy for anyone to see the problems. There are often reams of paper and a big backlog that detail these shortcomings. This is only part of the work. The goal of the discovery sprint is not to add to that pile of paper. It's important to identify practical, pragmatic steps the organization can take to drive improvements and change.

Discovery activities can involve some or all of the following, depending on the goals and scope of the sprint.

Stakeholder Interviews

Interview stakeholders who have a broad sense of the problem area, the history of it, and a sense of constraints.

End-User Interviews

Conduct user research to learn about potential users of your service through interviews, observation, and testing.

Data Analysis

System Review

Understand current VA policy, technology, and business process related to your service. Identify policy, technical, or other barriers that could make it difficult to meet user needs.

Depending on scope, it can also be helpful to conduct [technical discovery](#).

Process Observation

Related Materials

Pull together related materials to the sprint. This may include previous research conducted, reports, and other documentation that may help provide context to the problem. If there are related materials, refer to them in the sprint report.

Prepare Sprint Deliverables

Consider what deliverables your stakeholders need to make decisions. Options include:

- **An executive summary**

(2 pages max) that identifies the sprint challenge and scope, the research the team did, and the high-level findings and recommendations. This is often shared with stakeholders in advance of the rest of the report.

- **A sprint report**

(5 - 10 pages) that goes to the sprint stakeholders and organization's leadership. The report often includes the executive summary, observations, anonymous quotes, recommendations, and potential next steps.

- **A formal slide presentation**

Summarize the report, since the findings are delivered in person to the same group of stakeholders that were present for the kick-off meeting at the beginning of the sprint.

- **A quick prototype**

(depending on the organization's needs) may be created to illustrate a proof of concept. This is rare and will vary based on the scope and goals of the discovery sprint.

Readout and present to stakeholders

Ideally the sprint team lead should have pre-scheduled the executive stakeholders for a readout meeting date as close to 3 or 4 weeks out from the kick-off date as possible. This will ensure that momentum stays high during the sprint and that the sprint team is able to deliver their findings while everything is top of mind.

During the sprint readout, walk through your findings, answer any questions the organization might have, and discuss next steps. It's a good practice to thank leadership and the staff you worked with for their time and efforts.

You should then walk through what you did, your research, and how you came to the findings and opportunities. Use this time to share stories that you heard during research to cement why you proposed the findings and recommendations. It is important that you understand where stakeholders are coming from and deliver the results of the sprint in a way that resonates with them.

Wrap up the Sprint

Set aside time to do some or all of the following activities:

Team retrospective

A team retrospective gives you a chance to reflect on the work that you did. The retro should be blameless and give everyone a chance to have a voice in reflecting on the sprint. Discuss what went well, what didn't go well, and any lessons you have for future sprints.

Follow-up with the organization

The sprint team lead should keep in touch with the sprint stakeholders and partners after the sprint concludes and the report is delivered to make sure next steps have been captured.

BEST PRACTICES

- Focus on understanding, not solving problems during the sprint
- Maintain a neutral perspective to uncover hidden issues
- Collaborate closely with organization personnel
- Look beyond surface-level technology problems
- Consider the entire ecosystem, including upstream and downstream processes

SPRINT PITFALLS – WHY THEY FAIL

- No clearly defined sprint team lead
- Egos or strong personalities getting in the way of the work
- Not everyone is staffed to the sprint team before kick-off
- No members of the sprint team have participated in a sprint before
- Members of the sprint team are not fully dedicated to the sprint (time or attention)
- The sprint team is blocked in getting access to buildings/assets/people
- Timing of the sprint is poor (conferences, holidays, budget cycles, etc get in the way)
- The sprint team jumps from framing a problem to attempting to solve a problem
- Stakeholders are badly managed, or expectations are not made clear
- The air cover isn't high enough up, or doesn't exist
- Stakeholders are actively shifting
- The scope is too big, or poorly defined

RESOURCES:

[USDS Discovery Sprint Guide](#)

[OCTO Research and Discovery Handbook and Templates](#)

[If you have questions about this guide, reach out to the DHxp team](#)